

» INDIAN PLAYGROUND

Hendrickx stars in Lancers' title triumph



Vedanta Kalinga Lancers rode on Belgian drag-flicker Alexander Hendrickx's brace to edge out Ranchi Royals 3-2 in a thrilling final and clinch the Hockey India League 2025-26 title at the Kalinga Stadium in Bhubaneswar. The triumph of last year's sixth-placed side delighted a noisy, partisan crowd on Republic Day and also brought cheer to their Australian coach Jay Stacy, celebrating Australia Day.

Reflecting on the campaign, Stacy said, "It was a bit challenging. The Indian players joined camp earlier than the foreign players and me, so they were already training when we came in. We had to bring the group together quickly. We performed well and built confidence through the tournament. We kept getting better in small parts of the game, and overall, it was a very good season for the whole team."

"Our defence is solid, and that was a major focus. If you have a good defence, you can go deep into tournaments. We were not finishing well, and our positioning was not quite right early on, but that improved steadily. Against S.G. Pipers, it all came together. We scored enough goals to win matches and conceded only 10 goals in the entire tournament."

"Our goalkeeper, Krishan Pathak, was clearly the best in the tournament. Unlucky for him, he did not win the award, but conceding just 10 goals says everything. I like his confidence. His reflexes are very sharp. He is smaller than most goalkeepers, but he covers the goal very well. His saves are strong, his penalty-corner defence is good, and he improved as the tournament went on," Stacy



Triumphant: Members of Vedanta Kalinga Lancers celebrate after clinching the Hockey India League men's title. BISWARANJAN ROUT

concluded. Ranchi Royals threw everything at the Lancers in the tense final quarter, including pulling out its goalkeeper in the last four minutes, but could not break through. The champion took home Rs. 3 crore in prize money, while the

runners-up earned Rs. 2 crore.

In the third-place playoff, Amandeep Lakra's brace helped Hyderabad Toofans record a come-from-behind 4-3 win over HIL GC.

Y. B. Sarangi

SPORTOON

